A Teacher, a Tutor, a Friend: ChatGPT and the High School Experience

Abstract

Given the increasing emergence of artificial intelligence (AI) in education, high school students' perspectives on ChatGPT are underrepresented in current research literature. As high school student researchers in an English Language Arts course, we approached this gap in literature by asking the question: In what ways do pressures within high school communities influence students' perspectives on justifying or rejecting the use of ChatGPT? We interviewed 24 secondary students and conducted a thematic and discourse analysis, coding the interviews through the lenses of social goods (Gee, 2014), Figured Worlds (Holland et al., 1998), and positioning theory (Holland et al., 1998; Ingram and Elliott, 2019). We found that participants did not interpret ChatGPT within a binary accept-or-reject vacuum; rather, the ways in which students perceived the intersection of ChatGPT, social goods, and pressures informed the extent to which they positioned ChatGPT as a benefit or a detriment. Moreover, these social goods within the Figured World of school (e.g., high grades, learning, efficiency, ethics, humanity, and superiority) were determined and strengthened by pressures derived from other Worlds (e.g., parents, peers, and teachers). Lastly, we propose a set of general recommendations for policymaking at the teacher and administrative levels.